Module 3: The impact of the opponent analysis on training tasks

3.1 Including content in training tasks (operational strategy)

The course modules 1 and 2 have dealt with how we collect and select information about the opponent. The aim of this module is to ask ourselves how we transfer this information to training tasks based on the conviction that we should not confine ourselves merely to inform.

When using this information in training tasks, there may be many methodological questions that we consider important to study so that the information about the opponent can be analyzed and used as productively as possible

A. To what extent does the opponent influence in the preparation of my tasks?

There is no single answer to this question; in fact, we believe that the most important thing is to raise this issue. Then, our goal will be to find a solution consistent with our context that, probably and necessarily, will also vary throughout the season.
We think that Juanma Lillo's reflection in this regard is remarkable: "The situation can never replace the structure" (Lillo, 2013, p. 23). That is to say, it is not advisable to set up a structure completely different from the work carried out throughout the year for a particular play or moment.
Naturally, this does not mean that we do not try to adapt, improve, anticipate situations and prepare ourselves for the encounter with the opponent.
Below, we will describe a pilot study that looked at improving center backs' perception "by means of a specific training combining video images and tasks in the soccer field" (Ruiz, Fradua Uriondo and Raya Pugnaire, 2008, p. 45).

"According to some authors, the use of videos has proven to be an effective method for the development of perceptual skills" (Ruiz, Fradua Uriondo and Raya Pugnaire, 2008, p. 49).

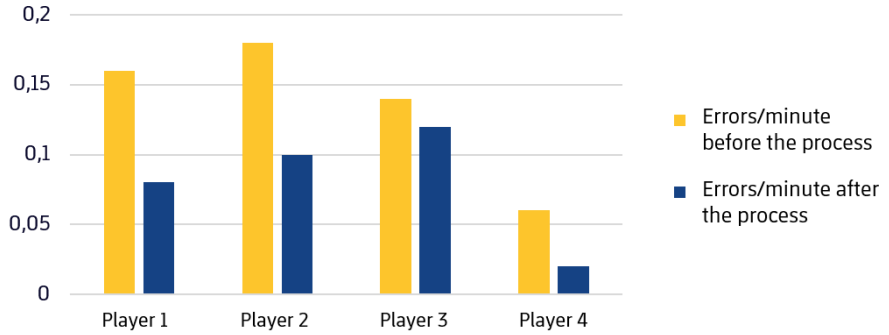
As the following figure shows, the results confirm that the training of factors potentially related to the opponent (crosses to be defended by our center backs) will improve my players' performance.

Table 1: Number of perceptual strategy errors made by four center backs according to the minutes they played

Matches								
	Before the process				After the process			
	1	2	3	Total	1	2	3	Total
Player 1	7/90	22/90	0/0	29/180	8/90	5/90	9/90	22/270
Player 2	0/0	19/90	13/90	32/180	9/90	7/60	9/90	25/240
Player 3	0/0	17/90	9/90	26/180	11/90	10/90	12/90	33/270
Player 4	5/90	0/0	6/90	11/180	1/90	4/90	1/90	6/270

Source: Ruiz, Fradua Uriondo y Raya Pugnaire, 2008. p. 49.

Figure 1: Frequency of perceptual strategy errors made by the four center backs before and after the process



Source: Ruiz, Fradua Uriondo and Raya Pugnaire, 2008, p. 50.

B. In which types of tasks do I include the opponent's contents?

We may think that these contents will appear in greater technical and tactical complexity task (small-sided games (SSGs), matches, among others) to track progression during training. It is true that these more complex tasks seem appropriate in this context; however, we should not neglect opportunities that may help us to fill our training with content.

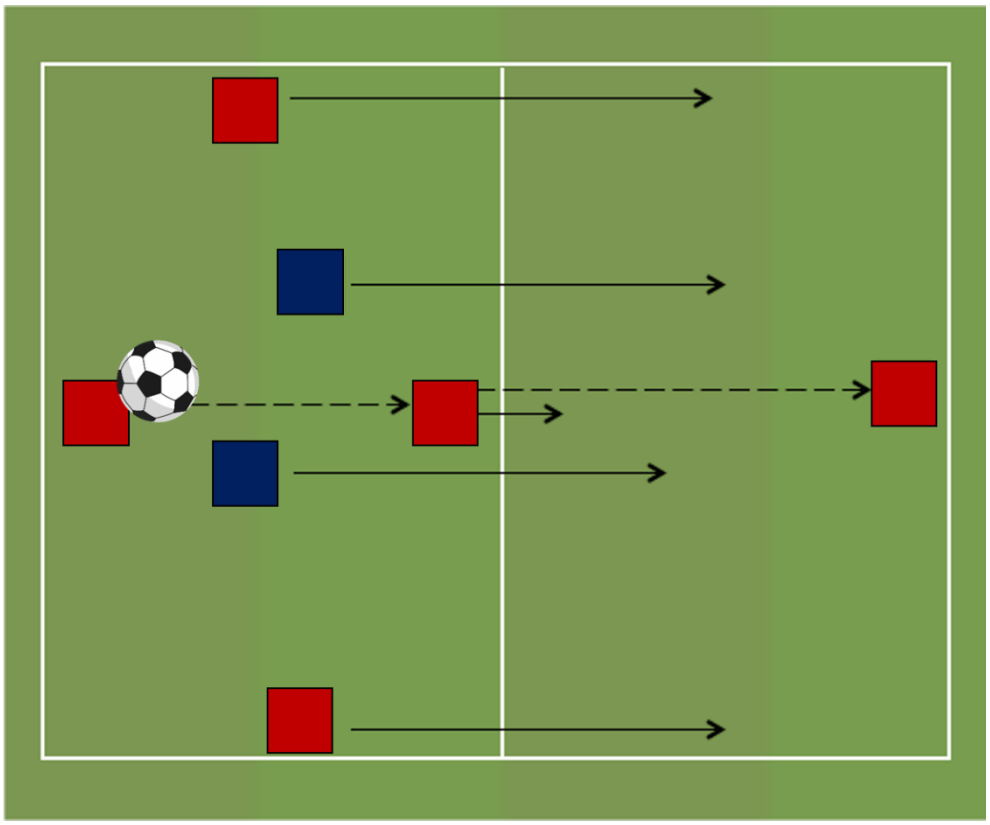
Equally important, the level of difficulty should be adequate and progressive and all tasks should be connected by means of one or more messages. These messages should be evaluated in a more or less complex way in most of the tasks.

We have therefore taken advantage of the fact that the opponent's information is available, even the simpler or initial tasks (warm-ups games, rondos, among others)
Below, the figure illustrates an exercise **(rondo)** in which one issue related to what has been observed concerning the opponent is analyzed.

Let us imagine that our opponent, during his defensive phase, experiences difficulties (due to his attitude or fitness) when he is forced to turn after a through ball between two players. We will work on this task to prepare our players to identify the situation in which we can **move**

forward when we succeed in "separating" two opponents enough to pass a through ball between them.

Figure 2: Rondo 4 vs. 2 to succeed in passing a through ball between two defenders



Source: prepared by the author

In this Rondo, we can see 4 players (the red ones) vs. 2 players (the blue ones) in a given space. The rule of provocation (signifying that it is provoking something) requires players to move forward to the contiguous space only when they succeed in passing a through ball between the two defenders (the blue ones). Once this occurs, we can (relacionar) pass the ball to the player (the red one) that is waiting in this space. At that moment, the three red players and both defenders move to that space to continue the rondo 4 vs. 2.

We can do this exercise controlling time (every 2 minutes we change the two defenders). We can also use our hands to carry out the same task in a **warm-up game-like way** so that players understand the tactical concept (in this case, the through ball between both defenders would involve the ball bouncing between them).

C. How do we coordinate the performance of the coaching staff?

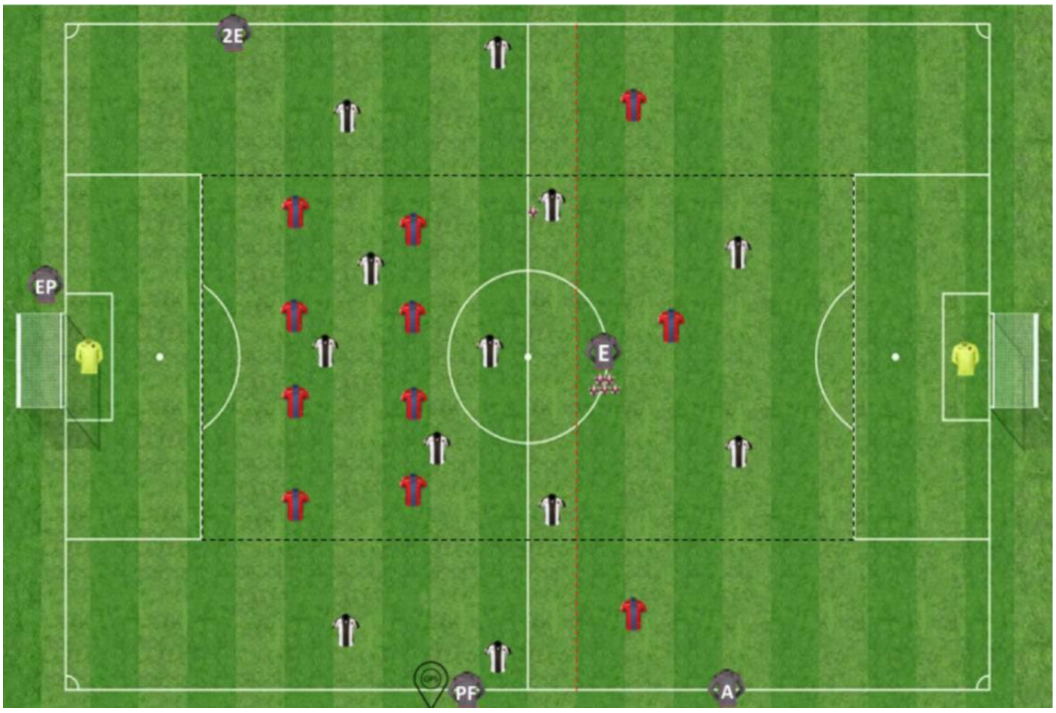
During the training task, there will be many different aspects to observe, correct or maybe they may have to give feedback on some of them adequately.

The coordination between the members of the coaching staff is important to achieve the intended goals. It will be very useful to ask each member of the coaching staff to observe a number of key aspects. For instance, center backs' observation, goalkeeper's position, defensive line behavior and attack and defense issues can be divided among the different members of the staff: the coach, the second coach, the physical trainer, the goalkeeper coach, the assistant, among others.

This division should be clearly done beforehand and it will depend on the number and the capabilities of the members of the coaching staff. This process must be clear so as not to overlap contents (it is possible that I am interested in doing it to have two opinions or perceptions) and also to send a clear message to the players.

During the task, it is also important the position of the coaching staff in the field. The figure below illustrates a task in which you can see the preferred position for each of them.

Figure 3: Positions of all members of the coaching staff on the playing field during the task



Source: Reina, 2018.

This will help us to ensure that the training task maintain the continuity we want and will allow us to convey the information more efficiently (corrections, feedback, positive reinforcements, motivational messages, among others).
At the same time, it will help us to gather useful and important information on what happened during this training session. This will be the starting point of the feedback process after the training session. We will deal with it in the next unit.

D. How do we deal with the sub-phases (attack, defense, transitions)?

There are many ways in which they can be include and they will depend on each team and coaching staff.
In the previous module, when we mentioned the elaboration of group or opponent team reports, we pointed out a way to group behavioral patterns within certain stages of the game. We will use this structure to include the opponent's contents in the training tasks.

- Attack **(OA)**, organized attack.
- Defense **(OD)**, organized defense.
- Attacking-defending transition **(ADT)** or defensive re-organization after losing the ball
- Defending-attacking transition **(DAT)** or offensive re-organization after recovering the ball.

We believe that the best way to tackle issues where the opponent's play situations are reproduced is to connect sub-phases with each other since one of the aims of the playing system is to provide resolving patterns after losing or recovering the ball. That is why it is important to know, train and adapt to changes from one moment to another.

There is also a quantitative reason; that is to say, the majority of playing situations consist of, at least, two playing sub-phases. It is uncommon to find a play where the team initiating the attack (OA) has possession until that play ends and the other team, therefore, is in the defensive sub-phase (OD) at all times.

Most often, within the same play, there is, at least, one loss/recovery of the ball without it going out of play, committing foul or scoring a goal. That is to say, these are sequences in which a team has the ball (OA) and, at any given time, it loses possession; this will force it to transition, first, from attack to defense (ADT) and subsequently to the (OD) sub-phase if it did not manage to recover the ball.

These are the most common ways of working with a given sub-phase:

- **In isolation: (OA), (ADT), (OD) or (DAT).**
- **Connected with the previous or subsequent sub-phase** (the main one is underlined), for instance:
  - Attack (OA) making a transition from attack to defense (ADT) after losing the ball.
  - Defense (OD) making a transition from defense to attack (DAT) after recovering the ball

Some examples of training tasks in which sub-phases are connected in this way are outlined later. In principle, it seems the most "common" way or easiest to assimilate from the methodological point of view.
The sub-phases could also be connected in the following order but it seems to be more complex or difficult:

- Attacking-defending transition (ADT), defending (OD) we do not recover the ball.
- Defending-attacking transition (DAT), attacking (OA) we do not lose the ball.

- **Connected with the previous or subsequent sub-phase:**
  - **(OA-ADT-OD)** Attacking (OA) and making an (ADT) after losing the ball and defending (OD).
  - **(OD-ADT-OA)** Defending (OD) and making a (DAT) after recovering the ball and attacking (OA).
  - **(OA-ADT-OA)** Attacking (OA) and making an (ADT) after losing the ball and attacking again (OA) after immediately recovering the ball.
  - **(DO-TDA-DO)** Defending (OD) and making a (DAT) after recovering the ball and defending again (OD) after immediately losing the ball.

There are many other combinations but we believe that these are the most common ones; however, understanding the play and other issues regarding the opponent will determine which methodological formula will be used.
During the session, we must not forget to put these formulas correctly in "order" to make coherent progress in the tasks.

Practical Example

Below, a number of practical examples are given to illustrate different formulas to design the appropriate training tasks.

Opponent's low defensive block:

1. Organized attack (OA) in isolation.
2. Organized attack (OA) connected with an attacking-defending transition (ADT).

Opponent's mid defensive block:

3. Organized Attack (OA) connected with an attacking-defending transition (ADT).

Opponent's high defensive block:

4. Organized attack (OA) in isolation at the beginning of the play.
5. Organized attack (AO) at the beginning of the play bidirectionally (small-sided come-and-go situations with two goals).

Training Tasks

1. **When attacking (OA) the opponent's low defensive block in isolation,** we are facing a low block opponent that:
   - will give us the ball for a long time.
   - will return to defensive shape.

Here we work on attacking aspects during these kinds of situations, especially on the ones described above:

- How do we create crossing situations?
- Effective finishing by improving players' position in finishing zones and positional superiority over the opponent (anticipation).

Figure 4: During the opponent's low defensive block, we attack (OA) in isolation

Code	Main content: 4. Occupy finishing zones. Protect near post (forward), both center backs in the box, right fullback to the second post.		Graph	Video	Picture
Space		N° of players			
Element		Physical quality			
Total time		Physical load			
Pause		Complexity			
Repetitions		Level			
Related tasks					
Emotional-volitional factors	**Tactical aims**	**Group movements**			
	Technical and tactical ways				
Information (BTTI)	**Revisions and comments**		**Description, rules of provocation and variants**		
Ball's owner: • Ball circulation until numerical superiority in the side corridor is reached. • Pay attention to the circulation so that it runs smoothly. • Think carefully if it is better to move to my neighboring position or to change orientation with a direct pass. **Ball owner's teammate** • Solve numerical superiority situations by engaging, attracting and/or dragging the opponent who possesses the ball away **Synchronize:** • Occupy pre-established finishing zones.			**Description:** • 8 vs 10 match in mid-field. • Rotate center backs (4 and 5). Forward (9) and goalkeeper (1) every X finishing. • Change the white team for the red one. **Provocation: rules** • The game is always resumed with the red team (attackers) from behind. • Start with mid-field positioning. • It can only be finished after a cross (marked zones). • Occupy finishing zones. • If white team players recover the ball, they will to drive the ball to the mid-field. **Variants:** • Mark lateral zones that can only be defended by no more than 1 or 2 players.		

Source: prepared by the author using *software* Keynote (Apple Inc., 2018).

2. **During the opponent's low defensive block, an organized attack (OA) connected with an attacking-defending transition is carried out.**

   Let us suppose that the content states that the opponent returns to defensive shape and from that low-block position he intends to recover the ball to start a counterattack, mainly by passing the ball to his forward. We can take into account the previous task and improve it introducing this content also considering the attacking-defending transition (ADT) in order to work on previous vigilance.

Figure 5: Opponent's low defensive block. Attack

Code	**Main content:** 4. Occupy finishing zones. Protect 1st post (forward), both center backs in the box, right fullback to the second post. 5. Finished with a mid-distance shooting. 6. Offensive vigilance.	**Graph**	**Video**	**Picture**
Space	N° of players			
Element	Physical quality			
Total time	Physical load			
Pause	Complexity			
Repetitions	Level			
Related tasks				
Emotional-volitional factors	**Tactical aims** **Technical and tactical ways**	**Group movements**		



Information (BTTI)	**Revisions and comments**	**Description, rules of provocation and variants**
Ball's owner: • Ball circulation until numerical superiority in the side corridor is reached. • Orient towards the circulation so that it runs smoothly. • Think carefully if it is better to move to my neighboring position or to change orientation with a direct pass. • Have determination to shoot from mid-range (6,8,10...) **Ball owner's teammate:** • Solve numerical superiority situations by engaging, attracting and/or dragging the opponent who possesses the ball away. **Synchronize:** • Occupy pre-established finishing zones. • Pay attention and communicate during the offensive vigilance (4,5 and 1).		**Description:** • 11 vs 11 match in mid-field. **Provocation rules:** • Goalkeeper always restarts the game. • The defending team stands behind the yellow line except the forward (9). • It can only be finished after a cross (marked zones) or with a mid-range shooting. • Occupy finishing zones. • If defenders recover the ball, they immediately will try to pass the ball to the forward (9). **Variants:**

Source: prepared by the author using *software* Keynote (Apple Inc., 2018).

3. **During the opponent's mid defensive block, an organized attack (OA) connected with an attacking-defending transition (ADT) is carried out.**

Figure 6: Opponent's mid defensive block. Organized attack (OA) connected with an attacking-defending transition (ADT)

Code	**Main content:** 1. Building zone. Look for depth losing markers and breaking the defensive line with the FORWARD and OUTSIDE midfielder away from there. 2. Positional play behind the two mid-center backs.	Graph	Video	Picture
Space	Nº of players			
Element	Physical quality			
Total time	Physical load			
Pause	Complexity			
Repetitions	Level			
Related tasks				

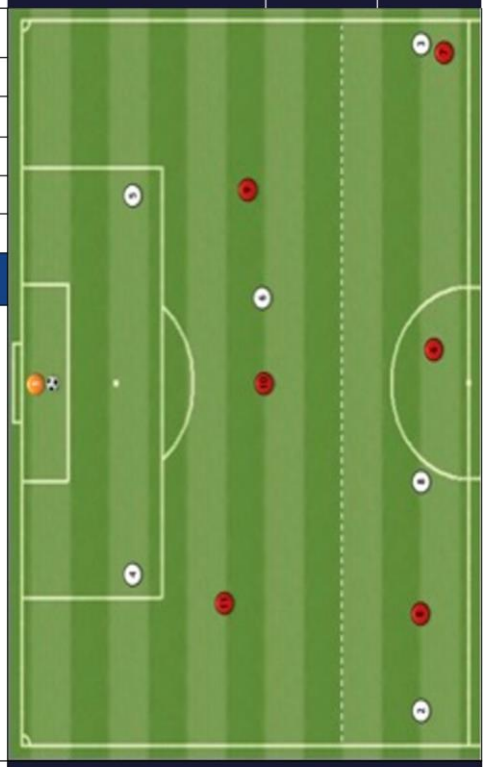
Emotional-volitional factors	Tactical aims	Group movements
	Technical and tactical ways	

Information (BTTI)	Revisions and comments	Description, rules of provocation and variants
Ball's owner: • Engage, attract and/or drag the direct opponent away to create some back space. **Ball owner's teammate:** • Give a line of pass to the owner of the ball who is oriented towards the attacking zone, delaying his position to avoid interception. **Synchronize:** • (8,10) lose their mark to support the player who owns the ball (6) occupying space behind mid-center backs (3rd man). • Reception behind center backs, with other players losing their marks behind the last defensive line.		**Description:** • 6 vs 6 match without goalkeepers in the field between both areas. • The aim (red ones) is to receive the ball in the shaded zone. • The aim (white ones) is to prevent the red ones from receiving the ball in the shaded zone and drive the ball through red or yellow goals after recovering the ball. • In view of the number of participants, two identical scenarios can be set up, so everyone can participate except the goalkeepers. **Provocation rules:** • The red team (attackers) always restart the from behind. • The defenders (white ones) only defend the shaded zone if an attacker invades it. **Variants:** • Modify space and/or number of participants to create numerical superiorities and/or inferiorities.

Source: prepared by the author using *software* Keynote (Apple Inc., 2018).

4. During the opponent's high defensive block, an organized attack (OA) in isolation is carried out at the beginning of the play

Figure 7: Opponent's high defensive block. Organized attack (OA) in isolation at the beginning of the play

CODE	Main content: OA Goalkeeper start	Graph	Video	Picture
Space mid-field	N° of players			
Element	Physical quality			
Total time	Physical load			
Pause	Complexity			
Repetitions	Level			
Related tasks				

Emotional-volitional factors	Tactical intentions	Group movements
• Desire to keep the ball. • Keep calm so you do not lose the ball either way (simplicity as a means to pass the ball effectively). • Be able to keep the ball and engage opponents. • Willingness to effectively support the owner of the ball by simplifying his task. • Build up confidence and self-reliance in the relationship with the ball (in the field).	• Engaging/ dragging away. • Passing the ball. • Losing their marks. **Technical/ tactical ways** Controlling, driving, passing, moving, losing marks and feinting.	• Ball circulation. • Players circulation. • Numerical superiorities.

Information (BTTI)	Revisions and comments	Description, rules of provocation and variants
• Possible receivers must adopt a proper body orientation (facilitating the direction of circulation or the attacking change of direction). • Support the owner of the ball constantly (Give him a close or far line of pass). • Center mid-fielders must adopt a proper body orientation to support the owner of the ball constantly. • Lose marks continuously towards free spaces. • The ball attracts defenders, thus, there are free spaces far from the ball. • Maintain width. • Look for numerical superiorities.		**Description:** • 6+G vs 6 in mid-field. • Aims: The white team must move forward to the marked area (between the dashed white line and the mid-field). • The red team must score a goal in the opposite box after recovering the ball. **Provocation rules:** • Goalkeeper restart. • The red team only has 5 seconds to finish after recovering the ball. **Variants:** • Variation in the number of red players depending on the success or failure to achieve the intended objective, the progression and/or the new aims.

Source: prepared by the author using *software* Keynote (Apple Inc., 2018).

5. During the opponent´s high defensive block, an organized attack (OA) is carried out bidirectionally at the beginning of the game (small-sided come-and-go situations with two goals)

Figure 8: Opponent´s high defensive block. Organized attack (OA) carried out bidirectionally at the beginning of the game (small-sided come-and-go situations with two goals)

Code	Main content:		Graph / Video / Picture
Space mid-field	N° of players 12		
Element	Physical quality		
Total time	Physical load		
Pause	Complexity		
Repetitions	Level		
Related tasks			
Emotional-volitional factors	**Tactical intentions**	**Group movements**	
• Desire to keep the ball. • Keep calm so you do not lose the ball either way (simplicity as a means to pass the ball effectively). • Be able to keep the ball and engage opponents. • Willingness to effectively support the owner of the ball by simplifying his task. • Build up confidence and self-reliance in the relationship with the ball (in the field).	• Engaging/ dragging away. • Passing the ball. • Losing their marks. **Technical / tactical ways** Controlling, driving, passing, moving, losing marks and feinting.	• Ball circulation. • Players circulation. • Numerical superiorities.	
Information (BTTI)	**Revisions and comments**		**Description, rules of provocation and variants**
• Possible receivers must adopt a proper body orientation (facilitating the direction of circulation or the attacking change of direction). • Support the owner of the ball constantly (Give him a close or far line of pass). • Lose marks continuously towards free spaces. • The ball attracts defenders, thus, there are free spaces far from the ball. • Maintain width. • Look for numerical superiorities. • Center mid-fielders must adopt a proper body orientation to support the owner of the ball constantly. **Goalkeepers:** Goalkeepers must adopt a proper body orientation, facilitating the direction of circulation or the attacking change of direction.			**Description:** • 6 vs 6 in mid-field. • Aim: to score a goal in the opposite box after goalkeeper restart the play with a short pass. **Provocation rules:** • Goalkeeper restart. • At the start of play, the most advanced attacker engages two defenders in the zone marked by the dashed white line and the opposite goal. **Variants:** • Introduce neutral attackers to: Work on the defensive reorganization in equal and/or inferior numbers. • Facilitate kickoff (although it is 5 vs 3). • N° of players depending on the needs, progression and /or new objectives.

Source: prepared by the author using *software* Keynote (Apple Inc., 2018).

E. What significance do set pieces (SP) have and how can we use them?

We might all agree on the importance they have since the percentage of scored or conceded goals on this occasion is significant compared to the total number of situations. Based on the data obtained from many

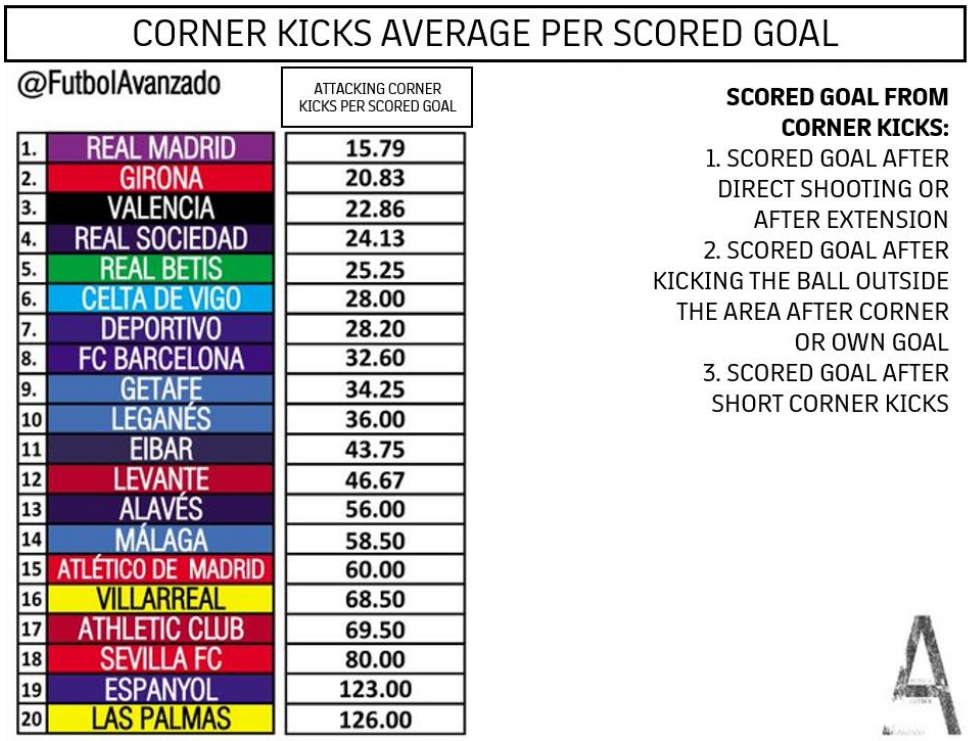
competitions, this percentage ranges around 30%. For instance, in research carried out by Anselmo Ruiz de Alarcón Quintero (2018) in the 2018/19 League, the percentage of set piece goals was around 26% and during the previous World Cup (Russia 2018) it reached 32%.

Another aspect that we want to point out is the fact that set pieces can determine a final result. In this respect, the study carried out by Rubén Maneiro Dios (2014) is very interesting because it reached two important conclusions: **the effectiveness of set piece actions is very limited but it is of enormous importance:**

- The effectiveness of set piece actions (SPA) is very limited: to take a **shot**, we need 4 corner kicks or 5 indirect free kicks. To take a **shot on goal,** we need 10 corner kicks or 11 indirect free kicks. To score a **goal,** we need 50 corner kicks or 36 indirect free kicks.
- These situations are very important for the final outcome of the match. "76% and 64% of goals scored from corner and indirect free kicks have secured a victory or awarded points to the teams" (Maneiro Dios, 2014, p. 127).

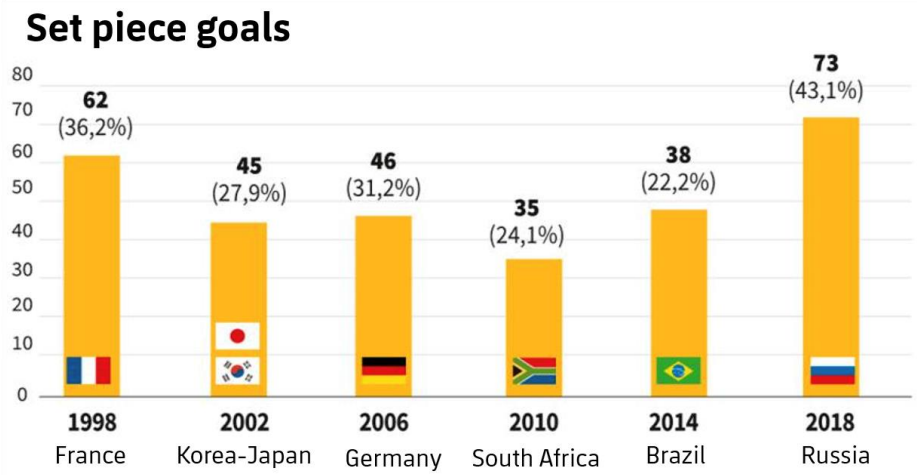
The charts provided below correspond to studies about different aspects of SPA

Figure 9: Number of corner kicks each team from "La Liga" (Spanish League) needs to score a goal. Corner kicks average per scored goal



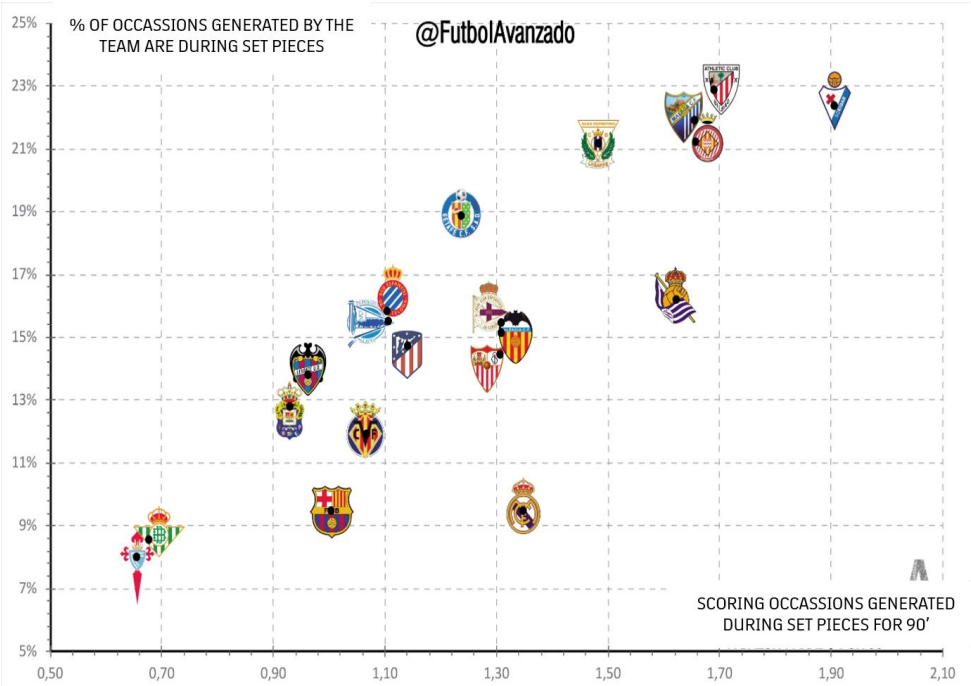
Source: [Untitled image about the number of corner kicks each team from "La Liga" (Spanish League) needs to score a goal. Corner kicks average per scored goal]. (2018). Retrieved from https://twitter.com/FutbolAvanzado/status/978215967317807106

Figure 10: Percentage of scoring chances corresponding to SPA (Set Piece Actions) (World Cup 2018)



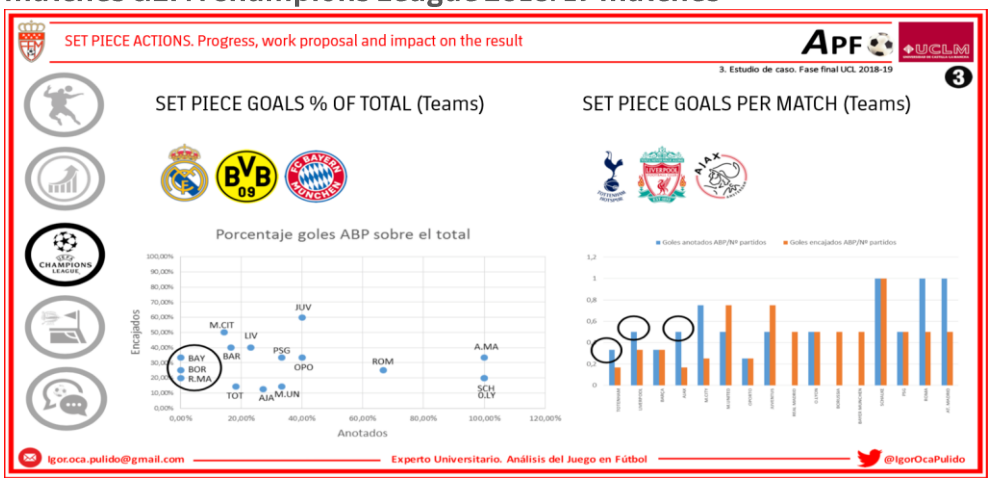
Source: [Untitled image about the percentage of scoring chances corresponding to SPA (Set Piece Actions]. (2018). Retrieved from https://twitter.com/FutbolAvanzado/status/973156968713084929/photo/1

Figure 11: Scored goals progress registered during SPA in World Cups



Source: [Untitled image about scored goals progress registered during SPA in World Cups]. (2018). Retrieved from https://as.com/futbol/2018/07/16/mundial/1531773505_515183.html

Figure 12: Goals scored and conceded stats during set piece actions (SPA) corresponding to round of 16, quarterfinals, and semifinal matches UEFA Champions League 2018/19 matches



Source: Pulido, 2018.

Considering the importance of these types of actions, we have to consider their training, and, in this particular case, how are we going to include the contents from the opponent's analysis

First, we can provide a previous theoretical explanation, using a graphic, video, photo, etc. Then, we can consider several ways to train them:

- **SPA without defenders:** These are pre-established positions and movements that are trained in a repetitive manner, in most cases we deal with the offensive phase, that is, when restarting works in our favor. It is sometimes boring and out of context because, in the absence of defenders, the situation adds the usual lack of intensity or competitive stress during these actions. It is sometimes boring and out of context because, in the absence of opposition from an adversary, the usual lack of intensity or competitive stress in these actions is added. This does not mean that they are not useful at certain times, especially at kickoffs, to explain the desired positions and movements without too much distortion.
- **SPA with defenders:** They prove to be closer to the reality of the match. Many times, we face the problem that players simulating the opponent, show little motivation and concentration, but we can also notice that, as they already know the movements that we want to work on, they anticipate a solution that usually conditions the good result of it.
- **SPA with game progression:** They are related to the fact of ensuring continuity of the actions after restarting of play with a SPA, that is to say, if we prepare an attacking corner, we must continue playing if the ball is kicked outside the area because this may allow the opponent to counterattack or it may involve the continuity of my counterattack. This will connect the sub-phases if ball possession changes, getting even closer to what really happens during competition.

- **SSG or SPA matches:** This involves increasing the number of times in which I carry out the desired SPA by simply entering a rule of provocation (signifying that it is provoking something). For instance, if we want to prepare attacking corners we can do it by using a rule of provocation that states that every time the play restarts it will do so with a corner kick. In this way, whenever the play restarts, (throw-in, indirect or direct free kick, goal kick, etc) it will be replaced by a corner kick, significantly increasing the frequency with which I work on this SPA.

The first two methods described (SPA with and without defenders) in principle, will be more recommended for explaining the opponent's behavior and also our responses to them.

At this point, we would like you to reflect on these traditional methods since they often lead the player to perceive SPA to be separated or isolated actions that do not belong to the real game. However, if we analyze the SPA we will agree on the fact that they are strictly part of an attack's initial phase (when it is in favor) or a defensive phase (when it is against). For this reason, we believe that we should not separate too much these actions from what they really are (at the start of the attack or defense) nor from the real context in which they occur.
This leads us to ask ourselves the following question: when do we train for a SPA? Traditionally, we have worked on it in the days close to the competition, even during the competition. Probably, this was done so that the player could remember it due to its proximity in time and also due to the type of physical efforts these methods required (short and intense)

In this sense, we may be able to improve the training and assimilation of these SPAs focusing on two of the aspects mentioned above.

- Use methods that more closely resemble the real game, such as SPA with game progression, SSG, SPA matches or other formulas
- Work on the SPAs throughout the entire micro-cycle, including them in training tasks

For instance, let us imagine that in the report we have prepared on the opponent, it is contemplated that forwards encourage center backs to move from their positions when they come to receive the ball getting closer to the ball owner. Therefore, they leave their usual zone for the moment.
Maybe, we can enter a rule of provocation that states that whenever the game restarts (except in the last third of the field) a forward comes requesting the ball and the center back who is marking him keeps on doing it. This opens up another way of working with the SPA since:

- This situation can take place at any time of the week and in many of the training tasks
- We can internalize and consolidate this opponent's behavior little by little
- It will give us the possibility to contrast the solutions planned
- We can contemplate new solutions (encourage players' creativity)
- We will work in a competitive context, and therefore, closer to the reality we live during the match (psycho-socially, physically, technically and tactically)
- Among others.

Finally, we want to invite you to reflect on the type of SPA that we usually train for. We will see the quantitative role that an SPA will have during competition. For example, an attacking or defensive throw-in is a SPA action that is not given enough importance because it appears frequently.

F. What tools do I need to simulate the opponent's behaviors?

In principle there are two key tools:

- Entering rules of provocation. In other words, as we have seen in the previous section, "forcing" the center back to follow the forward whenever he comes and requires the ball. It is true that, sometimes, as both teams know the rules of provocation, there may be situations where the desired contexts are not reproduced. To avoid this, we can only share that provocation rule with one of the teams. For example, if we want to provoke attacks from the wing with crosses because we have detected that the opponent allows them and they are vulnerable to these situations, we can enter the rule of provocation that "forces" or "rewards" finishing or scored goals from a cross. This rule will be shared only with the team that is playing its own role since the team that is playing the role of the opponent could adopt behaviors that may avoid these crossing situations.

  At this point, we can find several ways to enter these rules of provocation (Estévez, 2018):

  - Rule of provocation 1 (known by team A and team B).
  - Rule of provocation 1 (known by team A or team B) just by one of them, the other team does not know it
- Rule of provocation 1 (known by team A) and rule of provocation 2 (known by team B) each team has different rules of provocation and the other team may or may not know it.
- We must take into account the quantitative aspect because if we overuse it, it could distort the game excessively. This would cause

the level of transfer to the match to fall greatly. There can be a point at which "forcing" certain behaviors will take us far from the reality of the play.

- Position players that duplicate behaviors similar to those of the opponent (naturally or not). For instance, if we want to simulate situations in the side corridor where the opponent is constantly threatening the winger's back, we would place a player in the side corridor that has a tendency towards that behavior.

Using both tools will clearly help us to achieve the intended objective.

G. What distances and spaces shall we reproduce in the tasks?

We must consider the dimensions of the training place (particularly in SSGs) as another tool when it comes to reproducing the opponent's behaviors as faithfully as possible and adapt them to real situations that will arise during the match. By this, we mean the co-responsibility with the reality of the match.

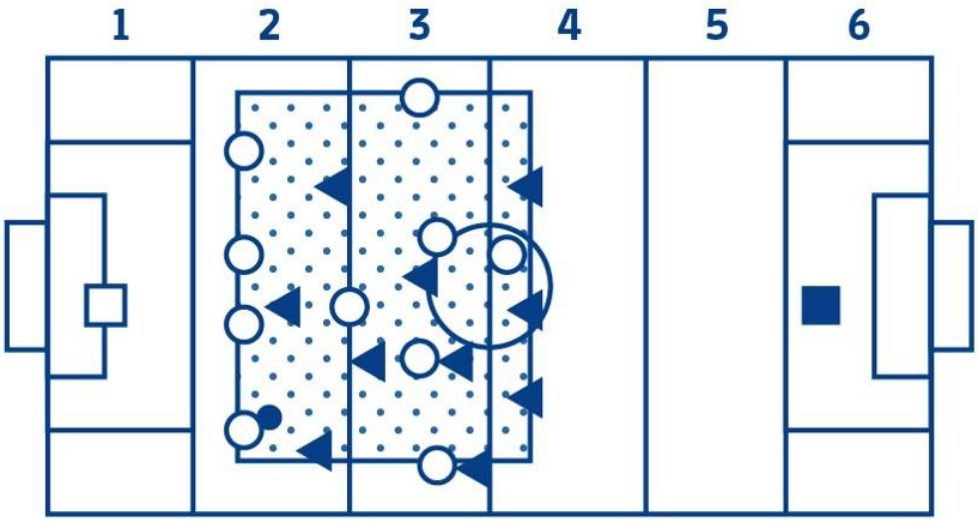
For instance, if in the defensive phase the opponent presses when the ball reaches the center of the field as a result of the presence of many players in that zone:

It will make little sense to expand spaces too much since it will give attackers extra time to make decisions. In this way, the process is manipulated and some solutions may appear but they will not work during competition.

Nor will it be advisable to reduce spaces excessively since there is a risk that we do not have any options that may later appear during the match. For example, controlling the orientation of the attack or moving an opponent from his position. These options will not appear if the space is too small since we will be probably concentrated on not losing the ball. Again, we would manipulate the decision-making process and we would move away from the reality during competition.

A study on the analysis of these distances and spaces is described below. The aim is to improve the training situations design, specially the SSGs' one (*Small Side Games*).

Figure 13: Draft illustrating the individual playing area in a SSG



Source: Fradua, Zubillaga, Caro, Fernández, Ruiz-Ruiz, and Tenga, 2013, p. 576.

Figure 14: General recommendations for designing SSG for training tactical aspects in soccer according to the particular phases of play

Table IV. General recommendations for designing SSGs for training tactical aspects in soccer according to the particular phases of play.

Aim of the SSG	Location of the ball on the pitch	Individual playing área (in metres^2)	Length (L) to width (W) ratio	Example of pitch size for 5x5
Build-up play	Zone 1 and 2	90 (range = 70-110)	1:1	LxW = 30x30m Distance from the goal to the nearest pitch end = 15m
Transition play	Zone 3 and 4	80 (range = 65-95)	1:1.3	LxW = 25x30m Distance from the goal to the nearest pitch end = 15m
Finishing phase	Zone 5 and 6	90 (range = 70-110)	1:1	LxW = 30x30m Distance from the goal to the nearest pitch end = 15m

Source: Fradua et al., 2013, p. 580.

In their conclusions they state “the need to analyze more accurately the preparation of the training pitch placing it in a more vertical or horizontal position” (Fradua et al., 2013, p. 580). In this sense, they conclude that the following pitches should be used:

- Vertical (more length than width) at the start of play in SSGs (zones 1 and 2) and finishing (zones 5 and 6).
- Horizontal (more width than length) in SSGs simulating build-up spaces (zones 3 and 4) (Fradua et al., 2013).

They also conclude that the design of these training situations regarding the goalkeepers' position can be useful
Specifically they explain that:

- If the ball is in mid-field zones (zones 3 and 4), goalkeepers position approximately between 22 and 26 meters from their center backs.
- If the ball is in the attacking zone (5), the attacking goalkeeper positions 31 meters away from their partners standing in the last line.
- If the ball is in zones (5 and 6), the defending goalkeeper positions between 15'62 and 8'93 metres (Fradua et al., 2013).

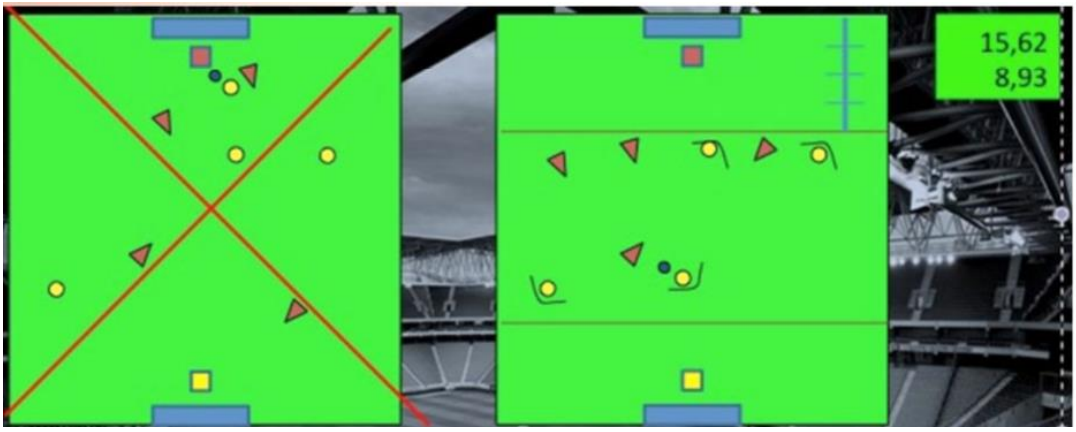
This last figure provides justification for a better design in SSGs that go in line with the real distances in professional soccer (this study is circumscribed by professional soccer parameters)

Figure 15: Results obtained from playing distances analysis

Ball position	Individual playing area	Depth	Width	Distance from the defending goalkeeper	Distance from the attacking goalkeeper
Zone 1	87.68±18.91	42.32±5.81	41.32±6.35	20.90±6.56	12.54±7.81
Zone 2	88.65±20.54	38.95±4.88	45.40±8.46	29.22±5.02	16.55±5.96
Zone 3	82.23±18.58	34.99±4.37	46.96±8.78	26.29±4.22	22.62±5.46
Zone 4	78.97±15.05	34.49±4.09	45.91±7.59	22.14±4.67	27.56±5.06
Zone 5	84.13±37.90	39.02±17.01	43.31±7.66	15.62±4.57	31.26±5.44
Zone 6	93.87±16.25	46.01±4.25	40.82±6.11	8.93±5.63	33.07±7.65

Source: Fradua et al., 2013, p. 108.

Figure 16: Design proposal for small-sided tasks related to the goalkeeper



Source: Fradua et al., 2013, p. 112.

One of the authors of these studies developed previously, (in his doctoral thesis), an analysis with some proposals that we want to highlight.

The following figures show the dimensions that playing spaces should present in these training tasks based on the intended tactical objective, directly related to the zone (Muñoz, 2014).

4 vs. 4 Tasks

Figure 17: Proposal of space dimensions for 4 vs. 4 tasks depending on the horizontal sector of the pitch



Source: Muñoz, 2014, p. 199.

Figure 18: Proposal of space dimensions for 4 vs. 4 tasks depending on the vertical lane of the pitch



Source: Muñoz, 2014, p. 199.

7 vs. 7 Task

Figure 19: Proposal of space dimensions for 7 vs. 7 tasks depending on the horizontal sector of the pitch



Source: Muñoz, 2014, p. 200.

Figure 20: Proposal of space dimensions for 7 vs. 7 tasks depending on the vertical lane of the pitch



Source: Muñoz, 2014, p. 200.

Another deciding factor when introducing different variants into our training tasks based on the opponent will be **reference distances** between lines. Specially the distance or spot where the players of the last defensive line "stand" (usually 3, 4 or 5 players) at different moments during the play after different stimulations.

For instance, suppose our team is in the low-block organized defense (near my own goal) and my team makes a long-distance clearance. Setting out a playing positional reference and a stimulus to determine, maintain, and/or modify that position will be very helpful to counteract

or condition the opponent's behavior in his new attack. We understand that those behaviors are part of my team's playing system.
In this sense, we propose designing a table that the team can used as a reference during the match. This table should take into account:

- **The playing sub-phases** (attack, defense, attacking-defending transition/defending-attacking transition).
- Majority **position** of players in low, mid or high **block**.
- Triggering **stimulus** (long clearance, passing through a certain own-opponent's line, recovering the ball, etc)
- **Player/s involved** (last defensive line, most advanced player, etc).
- **Positional reference** to know when to move forward or backward:
    - References in our own stadium is easier to identify (line, lawn mowing, benches, billboards, among others)
    - In other stadiums (they must be set when arriving to the pitch).

3.2 Training feedback

The main purpose of this feedback process should be to verify the degree to which the set contents during the training tasks, specifically those contents related to the operational strategy designed according to the upcoming opponent are achieved. To accomplish this, we propose three steps: collecting, processing and using the information provided by the feedback

1. Collecting Information

There are several ways of obtaining information to know if the desired objectives are or not fulfilled.

- **Monitoring the Development of Tasks.** This must be the most important step. We have already mentioned in the previous unit how important is for the coaching staff to organize themselves to carry out efficient monitoring.
- **Oral Feedback.** We refer to all those questions and conversations that we established with the coaching staff or with the players to obtain information about the intended objective. Here we must consider that:
  - Sometimes we will have to establish strategies to determine which member of the coaching staff asks those questions or holds those conversations.
  - It is also very important that these questions help to evaluate the desired objective, that is to say, they must fit the pre-determined objectives in the task.
  - The more concrete this information is, the more useful it will be.
  - Others.

- **Written Feedback (worksheet).** Again, we must emphasize the fact that the contents of this feedback must fit the intended objectives. We must not fall into a routine if it does not have a meaning to us because we risk losing significant information and, on the other hand, the importance that this deserves. In fact, to avoid this, we could "invite" players to make suggestions on this feedback collection. Regarding the feedback worksheets' design, we can design our own worksheets in many different formats (documents, pages, Excel, numbers, PowerPoint, Keynote, etc.) or other tools that help us design and share these worksheets (for instance, Google forms: https://docs.google.com/forms/u/0/).

An example of a **feedback worksheet** on goalkeeper's **training** is described below.

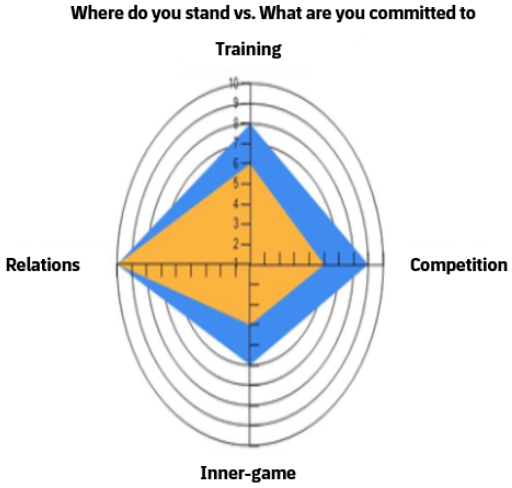
Figure 21: Feedback worksheet on training

ZERO GRAVITY

[redacted]

Competence assessment 08/05/2018

		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Training	Where you stand	○	○	○	○	○	●	○	○	○	○
	What are you committed to	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●	○	○
Competition	Where you stand	○	○	○	○	○	●	○	○	○	○
	What are you committed to	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●	○
Inner-game	Where you stand	○	○	○	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
	What are you committed to	○	○	○	○	○	●	○	○	○	○
Relations	Where you stand	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●
	What are you committed to	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●



Source: prepared by the author using *software* Zerogravity (Zerogravity, 2019).

Figure 22: Feedback worksheet on training (second part)



Source: prepared by the author using *software* Zerogravity (Zerogravity, 2019).

- **Other Systems.** We consider it in the last place because it needs material and therefore, high financial resources. In this sense, it is possible that, depending on the context we find ourselves, we may or not have access to these methods. We refer to systems that can give us valuable information during training (GPS, multi-cameras, among others).

  In the following link we can see a Sports Technology Symposium 2017 promotional video where they show us how FCB use the GPS

from WIMU company during the training of different sports disciplines.

RealTrack Systems (November 14, 2017). *Learn how fc barcelona uses wimu pro to win [YouTube].* Retrieved from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2FrQDivNQBE

2. Processing the information

Once the information from the training feedback has been collected, we must proceed to share it in order to draw conclusions based on solid arguments. It is important that this meeting takes place as soon as possible, ideally after training since the deadlines for assimilating the opponent's concepts are very short (especially in short micro-cycles or with several matches)

3. Using the information

Let us think that this feedback process must culminate in measures that lead, as we have already pointed out, to the correct assimilation by the team of the opponent's features contemplated in the operational strategy (OS) that, in turn, will be part of the match plan. This feedback will give us information about this assimilation process:

- Total assimilation. In this case, we can start working on other contents (that may have been contemplated or not) that give us more information about the opponent.
- Partial assimilation. We must insist on some parts of the contents. We may be able to connect with the following contents already planned. In order to do this, it would be advisable for them to have a logical order throughout the micro-cycle. This would help us to speed up or slow down the process without losing the "guiding thread".
- Null assimilation. Repeat content, probably modifying some aspect of the previously used task (spaces, number of players, rules of provocation, level of complexity, among others).

It is advisable to distribute the operational strategy (OE) contents during the micro-cycle, since if we leave this for the last moment, and its assimilation is not adequate, we would not have the opportunity to correct or start it again.

In the next module, we will talk about this distribution during the micro-cycle and the tools we have for it.

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